

Literacy Across Languages, Bodies, and Systems: A Personal and Community Literacy Narrative

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Personal Literacy Autobiography

My literacy story begins in the Dominican Republic, shaped by poverty, loss, and early responsibility before I had the language to name any of it. My mother died when I was seven, and my father's subsequent absence meant that I became a document reader, form interpreter, and institutional translator for the adults around me long before I understood what literacy was. I first learned to read and write in Spanish through school routines, copying, memorization, and the pressure to follow directions quickly enough to avoid being misunderstood. Literacy, at its surface, looked like correctness. Underneath it, literacy was about survival and belonging. I also learned early that not all truths were safe to name: as a child I experienced abuse that my Dominican community minimized or ignored entirely, and that silence taught me that some words open doors and others get you punished—a lesson about power and language that I have been unlearning ever since. Moving to the United States at eighteen added English as another gatekeeping system on top of the ones I already knew how to navigate. Academic English shaped how professors heard me, how institutions sorted me, and how much energy it took to be seen as intelligent. When I was finally diagnosed with ADHD as an adult, I had to un-learn years of believing I was “too much” or “too disorganized” and begin recognizing my nonlinear, visual, pattern-based thinking as a form of literacy school had never learned to read. Gee's (1989) concept of primary and secondary Discourses helps me name this tension: the literacies I carried from home—forged through grief, poverty, and necessity—did not match the literacies institutions rewarded.

My technical background deepened that understanding further. I hold dual bachelor's degrees in Electrical and Computer Engineering, a master's in Computer Science, and I am currently pursuing a second master's in Data Science focused on bioinformatics and diagnostic equity. I learned to read code, data, scientific papers, medical language, interfaces, and bureaucratic documents. These literacies matter because they determine who receives support, who is believed, and whose knowledge counts. For years I had to translate my own symptoms into language physicians would take seriously: my chronic illness went unrecognized for a long time, repeatedly dismissed as psychosomatic, which taught me that medical literacy is not reading a pamphlet—it is knowing how to perform legibility inside a system designed to doubt people like me, while still being sick. Today I understand literacy as the ability to make meaning and claim agency inside social systems. For me it includes Spanish and English, code and data, academic writing and family translation, medical self-advocacy and classroom teaching. The throughline is the same lesson I learned as a seven-year-old reading a newspaper about my mom's death: literacy is a relationship between a person and a system that decides how much of that person is willing to see.

Community Exploration

Drawing on a conversation I had with my father, his literacy journey began in a context where schooling was more limited, teacher-directed, and connected to discipline, handwriting, memorization, religious instruction, and practical survival. Reading and writing mattered, but they were not framed as self-expression or critical inquiry. Literacy was a tool for daily life: reading documents, understanding instructions, helping family members, managing work responsibilities, and later navigating migration, institutions, and technology. My father's dyslexia meant that copying from the board or reading aloud in class often led to punishment or embarrassment, so he developed other literacies instead: oral storytelling, listening carefully, remembering details, and building relationships that could carry information where text shut him out.

Our relationship with each other's literacies has not always been continuous. After my mother died, he was largely absent from my daily life for years. The collaboration I describe here was not given—it is something we built and rebuilt across time, across migration, and across the ruptures that grief and survival produce in families. When we did reconnect, literacy was one of the things that gave us a way back to each other. I could navigate documents and institutions he found difficult. He could tell me things about work, community, and survival that no degree had prepared me for. The translation went both ways.

What stood out in our recent conversation was how closely literacy was tied to responsibility. For my father, someone who could read a letter, fill out a form, or interpret official language held real social power. Literacy could open doors, but it could also expose inequality. If a document was in the wrong language, or a person felt shame asking for help, literacy became a reminder of who systems were designed to serve. I grew up watching him ask me to read or interpret documents not because he was incapable of thinking, but because the page refused to recognize his way of knowing. That experience taught me early that illiteracy is often misdiagnosed; many people are literate in practices institutions never bother to notice.

Technology changed his literacy practices significantly over time. His engagement shifted from paper-based practices to phone-based ones: text messages, WhatsApp, voice notes, online forms, video calls, digital banking, medical portals, and translation tools. These practices may seem informal, but they require judgment, trust, interpretation, privacy awareness, and movement across oral, written, visual, and digital modes. He learned to use voice messages when typing in Spanish felt overwhelming, to send photos of documents to me for help, and to rely on translation apps while still trusting his own sense of when something “didn't sound right.” This connects to the New London Group's (1996) concept of multiliteracies, which recognizes that people make meaning across modes, technologies, histories, and communities.

Our literacy journeys are different but echo each other. I had access to more formal education, advanced technology, and academic pathways. My father learned literacy through necessity, migration, family responsibility, and practical problem-solving. Yet both stories involve translation—not only between Spanish and English, but between worlds. We both learned that literacy is tied to dignity, and that institutions can make intelligent people feel inadequate when their language, accent, body, or way of expressing knowledge does not match what the system expects. In our family, literacy became a collaborative practice built across distance and rupture: he trusted my access to schools and universities, and I trusted his embodied knowledge of work, survival, and community. Together, we have been translating systems to each other for years—not because our relationship was always intact, but because we chose to build something that could hold us both.

Reflection: Literacy as Social Practice

These two narratives push me to understand literacy as a social practice rather than a fixed individual skill. Street's (1984) distinction between autonomous and ideological models of literacy is useful here. An autonomous model treats reading and writing as neutral skills. An ideological model recognizes that literacy is always shaped by power, culture, identity, and context. Both my story and my father's fit the ideological model because neither of us learned literacy in a vacuum. We learned inside systems that decided what counted as correct, valuable, and legitimate. In his case, dyslexia and rural schooling made him appear "behind" even as he developed sophisticated oral, relational, and digital literacies. In my case, being a CLD, neurodivergent student with chronic illness, shaped by early loss and poverty, meant that my literacies were misread as deficits until I gained the language and confidence to name them differently.

It is worth pausing to name something about this paper itself. A literacy narrative is an assignment, and assignments carry institutional pressures about what is speakable and what a reader is presumed ready to receive—pressures that Street's (1984) ideological model would recognize as the hidden work of literacy. A safer version of this narrative would mention "grief" without disclosing that my mother died when I was seven, reference "chronic illness" without describing the years of medical dismissal that followed, and frame my father as a collaborator without acknowledging that he was largely absent after her death. Those omissions would not be incidental; they would be an enactment of the very institutional legibility this paper critiques. Choosing to name these experiences here is not a departure from the argument—it is the argument applied to itself.

This matters directly for my future teaching as a K–12 computer science teacher. In my Pine Brook IGNITE placement and Minecraft unit work, I have seen students demonstrate literacy through digital navigation, block coding, debugging, design choices, peer feedback, and oral explanation. A student may struggle to follow written directions while still understanding the logic of a task. Another may not write a polished paragraph but can explain a strategy clearly to a peer or redesign a world to tell a story visually. If I only assess print-based products, I miss the literacy already happening in the room. My experiences remind me not to confuse access barriers with thinking barriers. A student who needs directions chunked, visuals repeated, language clarified, extra time, or another way to show learning is not less capable—they may simply be navigating a system that has not yet made their literacy visible.

My father's story also reminds me that literacy has consequences beyond school. The ability to read a form, question a policy, understand a diagnosis, interpret an algorithmic recommendation, or communicate across languages can affect health, work, family stability, and belonging. In our family, a misread document or an untranslated medical instruction could have meant losing benefits, delaying treatment, or missing an opportunity. This is why literacy education cannot be separated from justice. When schools expand what counts as literacy, they expand who gets recognized as intelligent and who gains access to support. In my classroom, this means designing multiple pathways for students to read, write, speak, listen, build, code, revise, question, and create—treating home language as a cognitive resource, and teaching students to read systems critically: to ask who a technology was built for, whose data it uses, and who benefits from the decisions it makes. My own research in data science and bioinformatics is that same critical literacy practice applied at scale—an attempt to build diagnostic systems that do not reproduce the patterns of disbelief I have navigated as a patient, a migrant, and a student. That is the kind of literacy instruction I want to practice: one that honors students' full complexity, including the journeys that brought them into the room, and prepares them to navigate and transform the systems that will read them back.

References

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